



HUMANITAS
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Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: American Preparatory Academy: West Valley 1

School Website: <https://westvalley1.americanprep.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

American Preparatory Academy West Valley 1 (APA WV1) presents a clearly classical-leaning program. The public materials emphasize a classical, liberal-arts orientation, high academic rigor, virtue and character formation, and a strong emphasis on Socratic dialogue, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), and memory work. There is explicit acknowledgement of the Trivium, mastery of fundamentals, and debates/seminars as pedagogy, along with a robust parent/community engagement framework. However, the public materials do not consistently foreground explicit theology, liturgical/community worship, or a formal Great Books program. Taken together, APA WV1 demonstrates substantial alignment with classical education in most domains, but falls short of the fuller religious/metaphysical grounding and the explicit Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis that some classical schools foreground. Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with clear needle-moving opportunities identified below.

Key takeaways from the six categories:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Strong on virtue, character, and classical aims, but lacking explicit theological grounding or liturgical practice in public-facing materials. Category score leans toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Purpose and Goals: Emphasizes human flourishing, virtue, and formation over mere information or job preparation. Category score: CLASSICAL.
- Curriculum: Centered on the liberal arts and Trivium; explicit Great Books references are less evident in public materials. Category score: CLASSICAL.
- Pedagogy: Socratic/dialogue-based upper-school pedagogy with rhetoric training; some lower-school memory/chanting concepts discussed in overarching classical frameworks. Category score: CLASSICAL.
- Faculty: Public materials present a professional, mission-aligned faculty and a “living curriculum” idea via leadership and staff; Category score: CLASSICAL.
- Parents & Community: Explicit emphasis on parent partnership, volunteer expectations, and family engagement policies. Category score: CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle section follows after the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL ranking, with concrete steps to reach full CLASSICAL status.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public-facing materials present APA WV1 as a classical-liberal-arts school focused on brain-and-heart formation, with language about virtue, character, and human flourishing as core aims. For example, the school describes itself as aiming to educate “both the minds and hearts of our students” and that “human flourishing is the goal of classical education.”
- The same materials emphasize rigorous academics and character development as central aims, indicating transcendental moral aims aligned with classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations): virtue, virtuous, character, human flourishing, classical-liberal arts, goal, education.
- Negative keywords found: Explicit theology, liturgical practices, or explicit theological grounding are not present in the WV1 public materials.

Why this rating

- The materials strongly express a moral/formational aim (virtue, character, human flourishing) but lack explicit theological grounding or liturgical/shared worship elements in the public-facing content. The Classical Elements rubric values a theology-grounded or liturgically engaged foundation; those explicit elements appear under the knowledge-base's broader rubric but are not clearly evidenced on APA WV1's site. Hence: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with potential to become CLASSICAL if theology and liturgical/community practices are clearly stated on the site.

Citations

- Our Philosophy and Vision language emphasizing virtue, character, and human flourishing.

Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The mission and philosophy explicitly anchor education in formation of character and the pursuit of virtue and wisdom, not merely job preparation. The materials state goals around human flourishing and the formation of good character, aligned with a virtue-centered aim.
- The program emphasizes a classical-liberal arts approach, ensuring content-rich curriculum and “concrete measurements” of character and academic success.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: classical-liberal arts, human flourishing, virtue, character, formation, goal, education, wisdom.
- Negative keywords: No explicit retreat from formation in favor of information- or job-centric aims appears in the public materials.

Why this rating

- The school clearly foregrounds virtue, wisdom, and formation as central aims rather than vocational job preparation alone, matching the Element 2 criteria for CLASSICAL.

Citations

- APA WV1 mission and philosophy statements.
- Mission statements describing formation and character.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials foreground the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as foundational to learning, with explicit discussion of a mastery-focused, sequential knowledge-building approach. The Trivium is explicitly referenced as part of APA's classical model.
- The public-facing content describes a focus on mastery of fundamentals and sequential building of knowledge, aligning with classical discipline in the liberal arts.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), mastery of fundamentals, sequential knowledge building, classical-liberal arts.

- Negative keywords found: A lack of explicit Great Books mentions; no explicit Great Books program is described in the public content, though several references to classical texts appear in broader materials not necessarily on WV1's West Valley 1 pages.

Why this rating

- Strong alignment with classical curriculum through Trivium and mastery-based fundamentals; some Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis is not clearly evidenced on the site, which tempers a full CLASSICAL rating in this category. Overall CLASSICAL.

Citations

- Trivium and classical curriculum emphasis.
- Mastery of fundamentals and sequential knowledge.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school publicly highlights Socratic discussion and seminars in the upper grades, with a rhetoric focus and opportunities to give speeches, modeling classical rhetorical education.
- There is also explicit reference to debates, seminars, and rhetoric as core pedagogical methods in the public materials.
- For the lower grades, while the explicit public content is less detailed about singing/chanting, classical pedagogy often includes memory/chanting elements; the broader classical framework is evidenced in the materials. (See the knowledge-base discussion of lower-school chant/memory in the broader Six Elements documents.)

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: Socratic, dialogue, seminars, debates, rhetoric, speeches, memorization/recitation concepts as part of classical pedagogy (as described in the knowledge-base materials about classical pedagogy).
- Negative keywords found: None explicitly describing non-classical pedagogy on the West Valley 1 site.

Why this rating

- The explicit mention of Socratic discourse, seminars, debates, and rhetoric aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy expectations.

Citations

- Socratic discussion, seminars, and rhetoric training.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials present leadership and staff and refer to the school's staff and governance. The West Valley 1 campus materials list administrators and staff by name, indicating a formal, professional faculty structure.
- Knowledge-base materials reference the concept of the living curriculum and highlight teachers as core mentors and exemplars; APA WV1 materials show leadership by named administrators (e.g., Laura Leavitt, MaryCarmen Gaméz, Heidi Franco, etc.).
- Public materials include references to governance and a community of teachers who form a core part of the school's culture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: faculty as mentors; living curriculum; teachers as core; named administrators; professional staff; practice of virtuous instruction.
- Negative keywords: None clearly present in public materials that would indicate non-classical faculty structuring.

Why this rating

- The presence of named staff, leadership, and a clearly defined faculty culture aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for the faculty category.

Citations

- West Valley 1 principal/staff listings.
- Public philosophy about the living curriculum and teacher-centric model.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- APA WV1 emphasizes parent and family engagement as a core component: explicit policies, opportunities for parent involvement (e.g., 20 hours of volunteering per school year), and a policy framework around parent-school communication.
- The district-level documents emphasize partnerships with parents, and the school's website and materials invite parent visits and participation in school life.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: parent/Family engagement, co-teaching with parents, parent involvement policies, volunteering, school visits.
- Negative keywords: None apparent in public materials that would suggest conflict with parent partnership.

Why this rating

- The school presents an explicit, ongoing commitment to engaging parents as partners in education, in line with CLASSICAL expectations for parental/community involvement.

Citations

- District Parent Family Engagement and parent volunteering policies.

Aggregate Ranking

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Explicitly state theology or liturgical/community practices on the WV1 site, linking the classical education with a grounded theological or metaphysical framework. Include statements about doctrinal commitments, liturgical practices (even if non-denominational), and how worship or shared contemplative practices integrate with the curriculum. This would shift Element 1 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.
- Curriculum: Publicly articulate a formal Great Books program or "Great Conversation" commitments across grades (even if staged gradually by grade level). If Great Books are already used in practice,

make explicit on the site how students access primary texts, authors, and the conversations surrounding them.

- **Pedagogy:** Emphasize and document explicit contemplative/scholé moments (restful learning) alongside rigorous Socratic inquiry, including explicit references to quiet, contemplative passages or moments of reflection as part of daily routines.
- **Faculty:** Expand the public-facing articulation of the living-curriculum concept by providing specific faculty portraits, exemplars of teacher modeling virtue, and descriptions of mentorship roles (model teachers and mentors) as part of the public materials.
- **Parents & Community:** Strengthen and publicize formal opportunities for parent education about classical education (e.g., book studies, lectures, or community discussions about the classical model) to deepen parent understanding and participation.
- **Great Books / Interdisciplinary Integration:** Broaden interdisciplinary and integration languages tied to curriculum topics by clearly describing cross-disciplinary projects and integrated units (history, literature, philosophy, science) that demonstrate unity of truth across subjects.
- **Public narrative around formation and character:** More explicit articulation of how virtue, wisdom, and beauty guide daily practice and assessment, with clear metrics and examples tied to classroom activities.

ABSTRACT

APA WV1 demonstrates a robust classical orientation, with strong alignment in Purpose and Goal, Curriculum (Trivium emphasis), Pedagogy (Socratic dialogue, seminars, and rhetoric), Faculty (named leadership and living-curriculum framing), and Parents & Community (active parent engagement). The Public materials strongly emphasize virtue, character, human flourishing, and a classical liberal-arts approach to education, supported by explicit references to mastery of fundamentals and the Trivium. However, the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category shows only partial alignment: theology, liturgical practices, and overt metaphysical grounding are not consistently foregrounded in public content, which prevents a full CLASSICAL designation in Element 1. The aggregate assessment across all six categories lands at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with meaningful opportunities to move toward full CLASSICAL status.

- **Religious and Metaphysical Foundations:** SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Virtue, character, human flourishing, and classical aims are present; explicit theology or liturgical practices are not clearly evidenced on public site.
- **Purpose and Goal:** CLASSICAL Evidence: Formation of virtue and wisdom as primary aims; human flourishing; classical-liberal arts.
- **Curriculum:** CLASSICAL Evidence: Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric); mastery of fundamentals; sequential knowledge.
- **Pedagogy:** CLASSICAL Evidence: Socratic discussion, seminars, rhetoric training; upper-school debates; speeches.
- **Faculty:** CLASSICAL Evidence: Public staff lists and leadership; living-curriculum framing and teacher-role emphasis.
- **Parents & Community:** CLASSICAL Evidence: District Parent Family Engagement policies; volunteering requirements; parent visits.

Notes on sources and keyword grounding

- The analysis integrates both the school's explicit public-facing content (as retrieved from the school's West Valley 1 materials) and the classical education rubric from the knowledge-base documents. The school's public content demonstrates a clear classical framework: Trivium, mastery, Socratic dialogue,

and parent partnerships. The knowledge-base elements provide a broader set of positive/negative keyword indicators (e.g., Great Books, scholarly integration, liturgical rhythm, sacred order, etc.) to ground the keyword analysis and scoring. For example, explicit references to the Trivium and Socratic pedagogy are drawn from APA WV1 materials (Trivium and Socratic pedagogy).

- The “Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1)” knowledge-base provides the spectrum of positive and negative keywords for each category, including terms like “great books,” “Socratic,” “Scholé” (restful learning), “formation through imitation,” “interdisciplinary harmony,” and theological foundations. These keyword vectors underpin the category-specific scoring and the needle-moving recommendations.

What would move the needle (specific steps)

- Publicly articulate and publish explicit theological grounding and liturgical/community formation elements on the WV1 site (Element 1).
- Add a publicly stated Great Books / Great Conversation program and demonstrate explicit cross-disciplinary integration of texts (Element 3).
- Expand and document contemplative (scholé) moments within the pedagogy, with examples of how rest and contemplation inform daily routines (Element 4).
- Enhance faculty portraits and “living curriculum” narratives with concrete examples of teacher-mentors modeling virtue and excellence (Element 5).
- Continue and deepen parent education initiatives (book studies, community events) and ensure open opportunities for parent visits and involvement (Element 6).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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